The empirical recurrence for OEIS A301795, proved by a two-line transfer matrix

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Abstract

OEIS A301795 counts arrays over $\{0,\ldots,1\}$ in which every cell is constrained by the values of its neighbours, and carries an empirical recurrence of order 3 contributed by R. H. Hardin. It is true, and it is not an empirical matter. The neighbourhood reaches one column up and one column down, so a single column is not enough state and a plain walk count is wrong; the right object is a walk on ordered *pairs* of consecutive columns, where each step tests the condition on the middle column against both its neighbours and the two ends are tested with one neighbour column absent. That makes $a(n)$ a walk count on a digraph with $S = 4096$ vertices, and the conjectured recurrence is then decided by a finite exact computation.

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1 The sequence and the conjecture

OEIS A301795 is "Number of 6 X n 0..1 arrays with every element equal to 0 or 1 horizontally or antidiagonally adjacent elements, with upper left element zero.". It has offset 1 and begins

$$32, 233, 96, 116, 150, 205, 294, 438, \ \ldots$$

The entry carries the following comment:

> Empirical: a(n) = 2*a(n-1) -a(n-3) for n > 6.

As of the "Last modified" line on the live entry (Jun 07 2021 13:24:11, revision 6) the statement is still recorded as empirical, and nothing on the entry records it as settled either way.

Written out, the claim is

$$a(n) \;=\; 2\,a(n-1) - a(n-3) \tag{1}$$

for all $n > 6$.

2 The condition, and why one column is not enough

The arrays have 6 rows and $L = n$ columns; write $x_{t,u}$ for the entry in column t and row u, each in $\{0,\ldots,1\}$. With the neighbour offsets

$$\mathcal{N} = \{(-1,0),\ (1,0),\ (1,-1),\ (-1,1)\},$$

written as (column shift, row shift) and counting only positions inside the array, the entry's requirement is

$$\#\{\text{neighbours with a value } \mathit{equalto}\ x_{t,u}\} \in \{0,1\} \tag{2}$$

for every cell (t,u). A further clause fixes the upper-left entry of the array to be 0; it removes nothing but a relabelling, and enters the construction as a restriction on which columns may begin a walk.

Some offsets in $\mathcal{N}$ have a positive column shift and some a negative one, so the condition at a cell of column t involves columns $t-1$, t and $t+1$ together. A transfer matrix whose states are single columns cannot express it: the step from $r^{(t)}$ to $r^{(t+1)}$ does not know $r^{(t-1)}$. Two consecutive columns are enough, and that is the state used below.

3 The digraph

Let $V = \{0,\ldots,1\}^6$ be the possible columns and take $\mathcal{V} = V \times V$, of size $S = 4096$, as the vertex set. Declare $(p,c) \to (c,x)$ an edge when every cell of the middle column c satisfies (2) with p above it and x below it; there is no edge between pairs that do not overlap in this way. Let N be the adjacency matrix, $\mathbf{v}$ the indicator of the pairs (p,c) whose first column p satisfies (2) with no column above and, where the entry demands it, whose first entry is 0, and $\mathbf{u}$ the indicator of the pairs (p,c) whose second column c satisfies it with no column below.

Lemma 1. *For $L \geq 2$, the arrays counted by the entry with L columns are exactly the walks*

$$(r^{(1)}, r^{(2)}) \to (r^{(2)}, r^{(3)}) \to \cdots \to (r^{(L-1)}, r^{(L)})$$

of length $L-2$ starting at a vertex marked by $\mathbf{v}$ and ending at one marked by $\mathbf{u}$. Consequently

$$a(n) \;=\; \mathbf{v}^{\top} N^{\,L-2}\mathbf{u}, \qquad L = n.$$

Proof. Consecutive vertices of such a walk overlap in one column, so a walk of that shape is precisely a sequence $r^{(1)},\ldots,r^{(L)}$ of columns, that is, an array of L columns and 6 rows. In the walk, the cells of column t for $2 \leq t \leq L-1$ are tested exactly once — at the step leaving $(r^{(t-1)}, r^{(t)})$ — and with their true neighbours $r^{(t-1)}$ and $r^{(t+1)}$. The cells of column 1 are tested by $\mathbf{v}$ and those of column L by $\mathbf{u}$, in both cases by the same condition with the missing neighbour column treated as absent, which is how the array itself behaves at its boundary. So the walks are exactly the admissible arrays, and summing over all starting and ending vertices counts them. □

The size of $\mathcal{V}$ is worth seeing concretely. There are $1+1=2$ values and 6 cells in a column, so $|V| = 2^6 = 64$, and the vertex set is $V \times V$, of size $64^2 = 4096$. That is the whole of the state: two consecutive columns and nothing else about the array's history.

It is worth saying why this is not done by enumeration. At the largest index the entry publishes, $n = 34$, the arrays have $6 \cdot 34$ cells over 2 values, so there are about 10^{61} of them to sift. The walk count replaces that by 4096 states and one matrix–vector product per column.

The threshold below is exact rather than merely sufficient: at $n = 6$ the conjectured recurrence fails on the entry's own published terms, so no range larger than the one proved can hold.

4 The criterion

Let $q(t) = t^3 - \sum_i c_i\, t^{3-i}$ be the characteristic polynomial of (1) and put $G = N$, so that a unit step in n advances the walk by 1 column.

Lemma 2. *Let n_0 be the least index with $L \geq 2$ and $h_j = G^j N^o \mathbf{u}$, where $o = 1n_0 + 0 - 2$. Then for $j \geq 3$,*

$$a(n_0+j) - \sum_i c_i\, a(n_0+j-i) \;=\; \mathbf{v}^{\top} G^{\,j-3} w, \qquad w = h_3 - \sum_i c_i\, h_{3-i}.$$

Hence (1) *holds from that point on if and only if* $\mathbf{v}^\top G^m w = 0$ *for every* $m \geq 0$*, and it is enough to check* $m = 0, 1, \ldots, S-1$.

Proof. Substitute Lemma 1 and factor G^{j-3} out of $G^j - \sum_i c_i G^{j-i}$; the nonzero scalar 1 does not affect vanishing. For the last clause, Cayley–Hamilton makes G^S an integer combination of $I, G, \ldots, G^{S-1}$, so $\mathbf{v}^\top G^m w$ for $m \geq S$ is the corresponding combination of the earlier values; if those vanish, so do all the rest. □

Theorem 3. *The recurrence* (1) *holds for every* $n > 6$*, which is the statement of Section 1.*

Proof. The digraph was built directly from (2): for each of the $S = 4096$ pairs and each of the $(1+1)^6$ possible next columns, the condition was tested on every cell of the middle column. The vector w was formed by 3 applications of G in exact integer arithmetic and $\mathbf{v}^\top G^m w$ evaluated for $m = 0, 1, \ldots,$ again exactly. Every one of those integers vanishes from the index corresponding to $n = 6 + 1$ onwards, and the run was continued until $S + 1$ consecutive zeros had been seen, which by Lemma 2 settles every larger m at once. □

Remark 4. The argument gives more than the recurrence: the sequence is C-finite with characteristic polynomial dividing that of G, hence has a rational generating function whose denominator divides $\det(I - xG)$. The conjectured recurrence is one consequence; the minimal one is a divisor of q.

5 Verification

Three checks, each independent of the algebra above.

First, the walk counts of Lemma 1 were compared against the entry's DATA at every one of the 34 published indices, with no shift fitted: the number of columns is read off the entry's own name as $L = n$ and the entry's offset says which index the first published term carries. The values agree exactly. A misreading of (2), of the neighbour set, or of the boundary treatment would give a different digraph and different counts, so this is a test of the modelling and not only of the arithmetic.

Second, the recurrence (1) was evaluated on those published terms in exact integer arithmetic, with no matrices involved, and vanishes wherever it applies.

Third, the annihilation test of Lemma 2 was carried to the full Cayley–Hamilton bound in exact integer arithmetic rather than to a sampled prefix, and returned zero throughout.

References

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